finance drug trafficking—aren't these charges absurd? They did not find any drugs on my person that day and yet they arrested me. Sir, you have done me great wrong and ruined my reputation. Why did I have to spend so many weeks in jail—did I really deserve it?" Noncommittal in his replies, Singh told Khan that he had just started his investigation and would cross-check all this. Later, Singh would admit to his colleagues that Khan's accusation of the NCB doing him great harm without justification had greatly pricked his conscience.

**Khan then surprised the** SIT with his knowledge of the NDPS Act, reeling off sections that would have a bearing on his case. Khan said he had asked for a copy of the Act while he was in the NCB lock-up and given it a thorough read. He then asked the officers why he was being charged under the section that referred to the financing and trafficking of illicit drugs when he had done nothing of the kind. Khan also claimed that in the lock-up, he was witness to how the NCB officers would arbitrarily up the quantity of drugs they had seized from an arrested person. Asked why the quantity of drugs seized matter, Khan told him that under the NDPS Act, there are three classifications for possession of drugs—small for personal use, intermediate for both personal and petty sale, and commercial trafficking. The law had different punishments for different quantities of drug seized and the classification they fell under. While in custody, Aryan Khan says he saw NCB officials treat some of the other accused badly but clarified that he himself was subjected only to threats, not any assault.



**"Aryan was a one-off case of a person from a renowned family. Yet with all the money power and best legal team, he still suffered for 26 days"**

**SATISH MANESHINDE**
*Aryan Khan's lawyer*

When Singh asked Khan to narrate his version of events from the beginning, he began by confessing how he picked up the habit of smoking weed when he was studying in the US. He did so, he said, because he had sleep disorders and thought weed would help him overcome it. However, Khan simultaneously made it a point to mention that in California where he was studying, smoking cannabis was legal. While Khan spoke candidly about his life in the US, he was more circumspect while describing incidents in India and admitted to no wrong. In a WhatsApp chat with his friend Achit Kumar that NCB officials had extracted, Khan had allegedly asked Achit to repay the Rs 80,000 he owed him partly in kind, which was assumed to mean weed. Khan denied it, citing as proof the fact that Achit was returning the amount in cash instalments—something his friend himself corroborated subsequently.

Meanwhile, Bollywood superstar and Aryan's father Shah Rukh Khan too said he wanted to meet Singh. The latter told his team that it was okay for Shah Rukh



GETTY IMAGES

**SAMEER WANKHEDE**

# THE HUNTER BECOMES THE HUNTED